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Harry Allen

Harry Allen is one of the promising young players keeping the tradition of mainstream jazz alive. He was born in Washington, DC in 1966 and raised in Rhode Island, and he was introduced to jazz through his father's record collection. The accordion was his first instrument but he was drawn to the tenor saxophone after hearing Scott Hamilton. Harry's impact on the jazz scene has been considerable. He has performed and recorded with Bucky Pizzarelli, John Bunch and Ruby Braff, and he appears at numerous festivals and jazz parties across the country. His overseas tours have included festivals in Rome and Nice and he has recorded for Nagel-Hayer and Mastermix labels.

Harry was interviewed by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive, at the Allegheny Jazz Festival in Chautauqua, New York on September 13, 1997.

MR: We are filming today for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive in Chautauqua, New York, and it's a pleasure to have Harry Allen, saxophonist, here, who has been called a "swing revivalist" in a number of places.

HA: That sounds dangerous.

MR: Yeah.

HA: Another favorite saying is "neo-swing." A "neo-swingist."

MR: Labels are dangerous and sometimes accurate but not always.

HA: Yeah.

MR: You grew up in a time where you could have, in your early years as a saxophonist, you could have been listening to Grover Washington and that kind of saxophone, but that didn't get you, huh?

HA: No it didn't. Actually when I was first starting to play saxophone, a friend, a saxophone player from Rhode Island where I'm from, suggested I pick up a Scott Hamilton record. So I bought a Scott Hamilton record and I heard the great big sound he had, and I said well that's what I want to sound like.

MR: That was really it then, huh?

HA: So it was Scott.

MR: Did you play sax from a young —

HA: Well I started when I was about twelve. I'd played clarinet a year before that and I'd been playing accordion since I was seven.

MR: We have it on tape now.

HA: Yes.

MR: What was the reason for that? No I mean, most people who play accordion, it's maybe a family thing or the family is into polkas, or—

HA: We played accordion because we all went to the church down the street, Our Lady of Spain — no, no, no.

MR: I didn't know he was such a comedian.

HA: This sounds too funny to be true but actually a traveling, a salesman came to the door, and knocked on the door selling accordion lessons for an accordion studio, when I was seven. And they weren't there for me, they were there for my sister, who was one year older. I was too young. But I showed such an interest. My father put his foot down and said, "No, take both of them or none of them."

MR: No kidding. That's interesting. That sounds like one of the stories we hear from back in the '30s or something — a traveling accordion salesman.

HA: It's true.

MR: But you learned chords and all that?

HA: Yeah, actually the accordion is a great instrument to learn music on. It's very good. It's probably even better than piano because you have the keyboard but you also have the buttons that have the chords. So I know some piano players who learned classical piano who don't know the chords, they just know the notes they're playing. But on accordion you have to know the chords. So it worked out well. Except for the embarrassment later on.

MR: I think you should get it out at one of these festivals. See how fast you could clear the room. There's been a couple of jazz accordionists, haven't there? Art Van Damme?

HA: Yeah. Art Van Damme, Charlie Magnante, a bunch of excellent accordionists.

MR: Well you never know — if the jazz market goes way down the tubes, you might have to get that thing out. Well what was your school experience like in high school? Was it good for your jazz?

HA: Yeah. The high school I went to was a small high school called Burrillville High School in Burrillville, Rhode Island. It was a very small town and a very small high school, but we had a fairly decent music department and we had a jazz band. And there was also, in addition to the All State music circuit they had, there was a band called the All Star Rhode Island High School Jazz Band and I played in that and we got to play at the Newport Jazz Festival and a couple of other places, so that was a lot of fun.

MR: Did you get to rub elbows with any well known arranger/conductors at that time?

HA: Not really at that point. I had met Scott Hamilton and Warren Vache and Major Holly and some people like that. Major Holly was very, very supportive and had me come down and sit in with him in New York when I was sixteen. And he later on introduced me to Oliver Jackson, who was the first guy to take me on tour — he took me on a bunch of tours around Europe which ended up accounting for probably about half of the work I

do now, from tours that can be traced directly back to the contacts I made through Oliver Jackson.

MR: When you first met Scott, it must have been kind of a thrill after listening to his records for all those years.

HA: Oh, absolutely. He was my hero.

MR: Has he described to you what he thinks about when he plays?

HA: No we never had any discussions like that.

MR: He's mostly self taught, isn't he?

HA: I think so, yeah.

MR: What about yourself? This is a hard question and I don't always ask it, but when you're improvising, what are you thinking about?

HA: Well as Stan Getz used to say that what he was thinking about was trying to psych himself into being relaxed. So I think about being relaxed. And it's sort of combination — technically, because of my training I technically know the chords that we're playing and it's not just like Zoot Sims played all of them but he didn't know them technically, he couldn't write them down for you. He just heard them. Well with me it's a combination because I know what they are, but I also hear them and it's sort of a combination — I've never really thought about what really goes through my head, but it would be some sort of combination of technically knowing what I'm doing and trusting my ear too.

MR: When you are in a situation like today when you have four tenor saxes, do you go out of your way to either play off what someone else is doing — try to play different from what someone else is doing, or do you just let it rip?

HA: Well both. You gather inspiration from listening to the other saxophone players or anyone else in the band for that matter. I'm lucky enough to get to work with Dave McKenna quite a bit and almost every note he plays gives me some sort of inspiration. But you try and get inspiration from the other saxophone players, but you also try to play differently. After a bunch of years of trying to sound like Scott Hamilton, I realized that that's not the way you have your own career is to sound just like someone else. Like from the stories I've heard, most every horn player has started out that way. They say John Coltrane sounded like Lester Young, Paul Golsalves sounded like Ben Webster — so I made an effort to distance myself from that influence, from Scott's influence.

MR: What was it about him that you tried to emulate?

HA: Well his sound and his harmonic assuredness.

MR: Did you go so far as transcribing his solos and all that, kind of playing along with them?

HA: No. I've never been a big solo transcriber. One, I'm blessed with perfect pitch, so transcribing a solo, I hear the notes as they go by anyway so transcribing is just a pain in the neck to sit down and write it. But I think I transcribed one of his solos for an

assignment at school, and I've transcribed several John Coltrane solos for an assignment at school. But that's all the transcribing I've ever done.

MR: What was your college experience like for jazz? Do you think it made a big difference for you?

HA: Well my reason for going to college, the main reason was to be around New York. I didn't know anything about the Rutgers Jazz Program when I went there. I just wanted to be somewhere around New York City because I knew that the real way to learn how to play jazz was just to go and do it, and go and listen to guys and sit in and so that was my main focus on my four years of college was going to New York and hearing people like Scott or Buddy Tate or any number of guys. But the school, the Rutgers program was interesting in that it was very small. I think my graduating class had four people in it. But I see so many of the people that were there during my four years at Rutgers, on the road. David Sanchez was there, Michael Mossman, Ralph Bowen, Steve Nelson, and there was a bunch of others. There was a whole slew of them. Most everybody that was there has gone on to make it in the business.

MR: Did they have instances where — I know some people have complained about turning jazz study into so much technical stuff that it kind of works against your inspiration.

HA: Yeah. Well that's definitely a thing that goes on. Another thing that goes on at school which obviously I had a problem with was a lot of schools, and Rutgers was no different, the kids were only interested in Charlie Parker or John Coltrane the saxophone players, and nobody else, they never heard of anyone else. In fact I used to work in the music library and it was funny, you'd go by the section and there would be Coleman Hawkins, Ben Webster and Lester Young records, and they'd be in brand new condition. And then you'd get to the section of John Coltrane and all the sides are completely frayed off the records, because that's all anyone listened to. But I mean that's the students. The teachers at Rutgers weren't like that. We had some awfully good instructors — Kenny Barron and William Fielder was the trumpet, and on sax we had a different saxophone instructor every year — Sahib Shihab was one, Bob Mintzer was another, I can't think of the others.

MR: Maybe you didn't go to class that year. Did your tastes in music work backwards. After working in your head with Scott, did you go back farther than that?

HA: Not really my taste so much as my awareness of where Scott came from and through listening to Scott I began to be aware of Ben Webster and Lester Young and Coleman Hawkins and Paul Gonsalves and Zoot now and Stan Getz. And so I went backwards in that sense — not so much a taste sense but just an awareness.

MR: Now there's so many guys to listen to, but I wonder if you've heard this thing written about you from the *All Music Guide to Jazz*? It says "Allen seems poised to follow in the

footsteps of Scott Hamilton. He has a warm tone, a melodic approach to improvising, and swings at any tempo."

HA: Well that's very nice of them.

MR: Nice. Now you're going to have to buy the book.

HA: I'll have to buy the book, yeah.

MR: And a recent *Jazz Times* in a review of your work with Keith in "The Back Room Romp" — have you read this one yet either?

HA: I don't know.

MR: "Musicianship is full of hot but lighthearted swing and tasteful elegance that benefits the material but is informed by a contemporary quality that makes these old songs more than mere chestnuts."

HA: Wow I hadn't heard that. That's very nice.

MR: Yeah.

HA: I should read the papers.

MR: So you're getting some good press. At this point in your career — I think actually if I was to look at my records I think you're the youngest fellow we've interviewed. Would you have goals, if we were to interview you again in ten years from now, what's your goal in this game?

HA: Well my overall goal is to play the music that I want to play, and that would involve being able to — getting to the level of popularity that would allow me to bring my own quartet everywhere I went, and play in the settings that I would like to play in. And in that way, getting to play—

[phone ringing]

If it's for me tell them I'm busy.

MR: We will pause here for the phone.

MR: Okay, where were we? We were talking about tax deductions and musicians.

HA: The Mona Lisa.

MR: Okay, we were talking about your goals, and you were mentioning working with your own band. When you get at a festival like this, you're playing with great people all around you, but I would love to see some bands, personally.

HA: Yeah. That is one thing that is sort of a shame about the music business, the way it is today. The only people that have the luxury of doing that are the people who have had enough success that they can get that sort of money and fill those sort of rooms enough to make it feasible to take your own band with you.

MR: What's it like to play — do you change your playing at all, when you look out at this audience, which is probably 95 percent over 55, and do you play differently for them?

HA: No. I don't change my playing any. I might shade the tune selection a little bit to what I think the audience might like. I mean I know, not that I am any expert on bebop heads, but I know enough that if I'm in front of an audience that I think would like that I can play some bebop heads for them. Play "Groovin' High" for that audience and for this audience play "Whispering," and take the same style solo that I would take in either one.

MR: That would be a good trick. Does it worry you at all?

HA: Yeah.

MR: You know the question. It's almost like you guys have talked about this, probably recently, that the audience out there may not be around forever.

HA: Well it doesn't necessarily worry me that much because there are a lot of places that I play that have a lot younger audiences. The jazz parties — I don't think that they're going to carry on too many more years because the audience is getting fairly up there in years, and also it's so expensive to come to them that the younger audiences are not going to be able to afford it. But there are a lot of clubs and a lot of the single day festivals or week-long festivals that you buy one ticket at a time for, that the younger audiences do go to and so I'm not terribly concerned.

MR: Why is it that the musicians that are playing mainstream — I guess — seem to be predominantly white and the audience is overwhelmingly white.

HA: I'm not sure.

MR: I don't know why this particular style of music is mostly embraced by white players.

HA: Yeah, I don't know what that is. Some of the audience I can maybe explain for economic reasons, maybe — it's a shame and it's not right — but maybe the black population isn't economically as well off as the white population and so wouldn't be able to afford to go to those things. Although there are certain areas of the country where that's different. I played a jazz festival in Mount Vernon and the audience was 99% black, and the most wonderful audience in the world, they were great. But I don't know why the young musicians all seem to be white. There are a few of course — Russell Malone, a wonderful guitar player — but not many.

MR: What do you think about the hype, the press that the "young lions" get? Have you ever been called a "young lion" in the press?

HA: I don't think so. I think it's too bad — it's great for them and their careers obviously. It's too bad in a way because I feel that somebody in an office somewhere is making the decision as to who is going to be able to make it, whereas I gather that years ago it was more like the best guys were the ones who made it. And today it's, oh well, you are the right look, you are the right this, well we're going to put the money behind you. And obviously that's not the way to do it if you're going to get the best musical results. But it's certainly great for those individuals. That's wonderful for them.

MR: When you were coming up through high school and then in college, did you play gigs that were far astray from what you really wanted to do? Did you ever get into the rock & roll scene?

HA: No. No, I never did. The farthest I've ever gotten is playing some weddings where they wanted jazz and having to play some Top 40 tune or two.

MR: Come on. Did you ever play "Tequila?"

HA: I probably have played "Tequila" once or twice at one of those jobs.

MR: What's the most favorite recording you've done so far?

HA: Well I'd have to say it's always the latest one. I've been fortunate not to have any ones recently that I really thought didn't go well. They've all gone pretty well so usually the way I feel is the latest one is the one that's most representative of my playing now.

MR: And your latest one was?

HA: Well I recorded one a couple of months ago that's not out yet, with Dave McKenna and Jake Hanna and Michael Moore.

MR: Good company.

HA: Yeah. And I recorded one just about a month before that with Kenny Barron and Al Foster and George Mraz. So those two would be my favorites as of now.

MR: What label are they supposed to come out on?

HA: One has just come out on Mastermix — the one with Kenny Barron came out on Mastermix, which is a British label. The other one was recorded for BMG in Japan — well we did it in New York but it was recorded for BMG Japan.

MR: Have you been to Japan?

HA: No. We're going over with that quartet in November for the release of the record.

MR: It seems to be pretty jazz happy over there.

HA: Yeah. I hear they have a yen for jazz. Sorry. I had to.

MR: I was waiting for you to do another one of those. What's it like with a small jazz label market? Do these people contact you?

HA: Yeah. I've been fortunate to be able to record a lot. I have about fifteen records out under my own name, mostly for small labels around the world. I've done a bunch for a couple of different small labels in the United States, I've done a bunch of records for the Mastermix label in England, I've done a bunch of records for the Nagel-Hayer label in Germany. The only big label I've ever recorded for under my name was BMG and I'm getting ready to do the fourth one in December.

MR: What kind of deal do they make with you these days, if you don't mind me prying? Do you get an extra amount of money if they sell a lot or is it just flat?

HA: Yeah, you get an advance against royalties. And then once you've gained your advance back through royalties then you get royalties.

MR: And does it vary from label to label how much control they try to impart onto your recording?

HA: Yeah. From what I gather from talking to people, the bigger the labels the more control they want and everything. I'm very, very lucky with the BMG people because the producer that we have is excellent and he knows when to say something and when to sit back, and he also lets me make a lot of the key decisions. It's never a you're going to do this, you're going to do that. He'll have an idea, I'll have an idea, and we'll talk about it. But he lets me — more or less — do the things I want.

MR: Are you a player that's constantly looking for different sound, different horn, different mouthpiece and all that?

HA: Different mouthpiece yeah. And sound is probably the most important thing for me for the saxophone. I seem to get very frustrated when I can't get the exact sound I want and so I switch mouthpieces quite often. I have a nice collection.

MR: Yeah? The older veteran musicians we've talked to often times comment that the younger players have great technical skill and all that but they all sound the same.

HA: It's true with a lot of the younger players.

MR: Why do they all sound the same?

HA: Because they all have grown up listening to — I mean this is of course an over-generalization — but most young players have grown up listening to John Coltrane and emulating him. Imagine if of the big three of Coleman Hawkins and Ben Webster and Lester Young, imagine if there was only one, and everybody was a disciple of one rather — then everybody would come out sounding a lot more alike. But people pick different heroes. Well today it's mostly John Coltrane. So you have a lot of people that sound like descendants of John Coltrane, which is too bad because there are a lot of other players of John Coltrane's peers that were equally as good, but just didn't get all the disciples that John did — most notably Sonny Rollins.

MR: That's true.

HA: Why aren't there more people that are disciples of Sonny Rollins? Who knows? I mean I like Sonny Rollins because he had such a wonderful sound, you know he had a great sound.

MR: How did he get that sound, you know, he almost sounds like he's growling into the horn at times.

HA: Yeah, I don't know. I've never seen him play live. But I don't know. But he's got a great sound.

MR: Who out there amongst the younger players do you enjoy these days?

HA: Well I mean if you're talking about in the range of all the instruments there are a lot of guys. Bill Charlap, wonderful, wonderful piano player; Russell Malone, a great guitar

player; Joe Cohn is a great guitar player; Larry Goldings is a great piano player; Chris Potter is a wonderful saxophone player.

MR: Now there's a guy that started out pretty young too, didn't he?

HA: Yeah, I would think so.

MR: In fact I think there was something in this article I wanted to — oh yeah, talking about "while tenor saxophonist Allen, though only in his twenties, plays with a mature command of the genre." When did this album come out? "Back Room Romp?"

HA: It was at least a couple of years ago.

MR: Well maybe you were still in your twenties then.

HA: Oh, yeah. I'm thirty now.

MR: So I thought that was a mistake. I thought that was a publicity stunt.

HA: No. It had to have been three years ago or close to it. Two, three years ago.

MR: It takes a while for these records to get out, doesn't it?

HA: Well that's been out for a while, that record.

MR: Oh, so it just got reviewed.

HA: Yeah.

MR: So you're thirty now, let's see, you'll be a veteran jazz musician in your seventies when it's two thousand— I can't do this math. I'm just wondering, where is jazz going to be in thirty years. Because when you look at the history of jazz it's moved so fast. Sometimes I feel it moves too fast for its own good you know. Like Miles never seemed to be happy with what he was doing and the audience would just catch up with him and then he'd be somewhere else.

HA: Well it's hard to say what's going to happen with jazz, but whatever happens, I just hope I'm in the middle of it. That's the main thing.

MR: Do you anticipate that you're going to be able to make a living in this music? You don't see why not.

HA: Yeah. I've had a lot of experiences that give me hope, and here's one of them. I was playing at a college somewhere in Iowa in a small — I forget the name of the town. But there was a college in Iowa and they had a light engineer that was there that the only reason he was there was he had done the lighting for the rock & roll show the night before. And they said oh just leave the stuff and do the jazz concert. And he heard us at the jazz concert and he came up to us afterwards and said, "Wow, that's the most beautiful music I've ever heard." He'd never heard it. Once he did hear it, he loved it. And I think a lot of people are like that and the press has weird notions of what is jazz and what isn't jazz, and a lot of people when they hear jazz like this, who swear that they don't like jazz, like this. So I'm confident that there will always be an audience for it. It's up to us to promote it in such a way that the audience knows about it.

MR: Yeah. We need more audience. I don't know if we need a lot more players. I'm concerned sometimes about the amount of players that are coming out of music colleges and where are they all going to go? We need to get more audience to go with it I guess.

HA: It's all just the publicity thing. If we can get the right publicity and pick the right — you know if the music industry went on a quality basis and promoted it right, I don't think there would be a problem getting the audience.

MR: What do you say when someone says to you yeah, I love jazz, I listen to Kenny G and Najee and that kind of thing.

HA: Well I have a great one for you. Last week I was in Denver, Colorado and I went into the gift shop of the hotel and there was a young woman behind the desk and saw my saxophone and said, "Oh what is that?" I said, "A saxophone." "Oh, that's my favorite instrument. My two favorite saxophone players are Kenny G and Bill Clinton." Now there's a lady who knows her saxophones. I mean Kenny G, that's not my favorite type of music. But he can play the saxophone. That's not my favorite type of music. Bill Clinton on the other hand—

MR: Oh, please. Well Kenny, you know, he found a niche. You know you had Chuck Mangione in the '70s and early '80s who was basically doing the same kind of thing. He was writing nice sounding tunes.

HA: I don't object to Kenny G's success and Kenny G's music. It's a little disconcerting when they call it jazz because it's certainly as far away from what I do as can be. And obviously I feel that what I do is jazz, and I think it confuses the public into thinking that that is really what jazz is, not what I do. So I wish that didn't take place. But obviously there's room for everybody to play any kind of music anyone wants to, and there should be room enough for everyone to be successful.

MR: I think we could fit the accordion in there too, don't you?

HA: Maybe not.

MR: Oh, well. Well I want to thank you for finding the time today to fit this in. I know you've been working kind of a crazy schedule here. What's up next for you?

HA: I go to England for five weeks next week, and then I come home and then go right back to Japan for that tour.

MR: When you go to Japan you said you're going with a band. When you go to England do you take people with you?

HA: Sometimes I take a quartet with me, other times, this particular time I'm not. There are a bunch of wonderful musicians in London, or all around England, who I go over and work with.

MR: Is Ronnie Scott still there? That club?

HA: The club is still there. Ronnie Scott recently died but the club is still going.

MR: Is it different playing with English musicians?

HA: Not really. Of all the foreign countries, England is the one that had a jazz scene for many, many years. They had bands in the '40s touring England. None of the other countries have that to my knowledge. So the musicianship in England is the most similar to the musicianship in the United States, because they've had that history of it.

MR: All right. Well thanks again for your time.

HA: Thank you.

MR: And I hope you have safe trips. Do you get to go on any of these? All right.

HA: She's coming to Japan. I took her to Chautauqua.

MR: Chautauqua. Yeah watch out in Japan, I hear it's extremely expensive. All right thanks again, and best of luck with your career.

HA: My pleasure.

MR: We'll see you again in ten years and do this.

HA: Wonderful.